

Art and Soul

Bihar
WEST BENGAL

A treasure trove of works by master artists is unearthed by students of a prestigious college while restoring their alma mater to its lost glory

Orissa

KOLKATA

SUVASHIS MULLICK



BHATTACHARYA WITH RESTORED WORKS AT THE ART COLLEGE

| By Abhijit Dasgupta |

Four years ago, it was a dilapidated building with dirty walls, its once gleaming Burma teak staircase shamefully covered in cheap plastic, 125-year-old Rajasthani murals callously splashed with limewash. Broken furniture and dishevelled gardens added to the decay of this once-glorious building. The decadence of the Government College of Art and Craft in Kolkata then inspired two ex-students to return their alma mater to its lost glory. Dipali Bhattacharya and Jogen Chowdhury got together to begin preliminary restoration with the Rs 20,000 that the latter put together. Chowdhury put in another Rs 4 lakh after that ran out. Former students then began to chip in with funds—Shakti Burman gave Rs 6 lakh while Sunil Das donated Rs 8 lakh. Gradually, more and more former students, now artists, came forward with monetary help. Today, the college is well out of lack of intensive care, and quite alive.

Manoj Sarkar was acting principal when the operation began in 2006 and a treasure trove of some 20,000 pieces of art was discovered in an old loft. These were the final year submissions of past and present artists, former

students of the college. "Hundreds of pieces of beautiful old furniture were dragged out of godowns, repaired and polished—priceless display units, corner tables, chairs and large tables that existed for the past 150 years," says Bhattacharya. "Everywhere we looked, we found hidden treasures—masterpieces of art and sculpture, priceless books." The most precious of the lot was Rabindranath Tagore's catalogue of his first art exhibition held in this college, a preview to his Paris show, and his nephew Abanindranath's reclining chair.

"The change has been phenomenal. It began in a small way and suddenly a dam of enthusiasm broke and produced an unprecedented initiative of students serving their alma mater," says Sushanta Das, an ex-student. Craftsmen from Jaipur meticulously worked on every inch of the arched wall behind the reception area, on all the three floors and on the building facade. Now, former students plan to contribute two paintings apiece that will be auctioned to create a corpus for medical insurance for the women who model for students. Where there's a will, there's certainly a way.